PRIORITY 4 OF 33 · SCORE 3.9

Agriculture

USDA brings two strong targets: SNAP retailer trafficking and child meal sponsor fraud, the pattern behind Minnesota's $250M Feeding Our Future case. Both are DOJ whistleblower priorities (SNAP and day care). Public data name the retailers and the grantees, but not the transactions, so we score entities, not purchases.

INVESTIGATIONS WE PROPOSE

- **USDA-1** SNAP retailer clusters near disqualified stores. **First prototype.** One-page pitch available.
- **USDA-2** CACFP and summer meal sponsors claiming beyond capacity. One-page pitch available.
- **USDA-3** Farm disaster payments far above county peers.

EXPOSURE

- SNAP: $10.2B improper (10.9%). Child and Adult Care Food Program: 10.5%. Emergency Conservation Program: 55.5%. Noninsured Crop Disaster Assistance: 10.6%. (GAO, FY2025)
- Feeding Our Future: $250M scheme, 78 people charged.

PUBLIC DATA WE USE

- **SNAP authorized retailer data** (store type, location, authorization dates) and published retailer disqualification actions.
- **USAspending** grants and payments, including farm program and nutrition grants to states and sponsors.
- **State CACFP sponsor and site lists**, where states publish them.
- **USDA OIG reports** and DOJ releases.

HOW WE DETECT IT

1. **Retailer outliers:** small stores in dense clusters, new authorizations near already disqualified stores, and owners linked to past violators.
2. **Meal sponsor anomalies:** sites claiming more meals than local child population supports, sudden growth, and shared sponsors across many sites.
3. **Farm disaster payments:** recipients far above local peers, or payments tied to entities with shared officers.

FIRST PROTOTYPE

A SNAP retailer risk map for two states, scoring each store against nearby peers and known disqualified stores, plus a sponsor screen for one state that publishes CACFP site lists.

SCORECARD

Fraud savings identified
● Pending

Phase 1 window
Weeks 6–10
Dec 7, 2026 to Jan 22, 2027

Workstream
Wave 1 and Wave 2 deep dives

FY2026 outlays
$220B · budget rank 7

Leads go to
FNS, USDA OIG, state agencies

WHY PRIORITY 4

Exposure	●●●●○
Public data	●●●○○
SBA method fit	●●●●○
Actionability	●●●●●

TOOL PREVIEW

SNAP retailer and meal sponsor risk map. See the wireframe of the screen USDA would receive.

On the site: Tool previews, USDA SNAP retailer map.

OUR REVIEW, DELIVERED WEEK 10

SNAP retailer risk map for two states; sponsor screen for one state; farm payment outlier table; review memo.

Every lead goes to an Inspector General or DOJ as a referral package with sources and caveats. Nothing is published.

WHAT WE ASK OF USDA

Phase 2 data: SNAP EBT transactions (via states), retailer redemption data, CACFP claims.

What it enables: Trafficking from transaction patterns; sponsor claim tests.

Access route: FNS; USDA OIG; state agencies.

LIMITS

SNAP redemption data by store are not public, so trafficking is inferred from location and ownership, not sales. CACFP data vary by state.

SOURCES

- GAO-26-108694: FY2025 improper payments
- NBC: Minnesota child care findings and Feeding Our Future
- DOJ whistleblower program scope

Scores and plans are our judgment from public sources. Risk indicators are leads for Inspectors General or DOJ, not accusations.

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